Title: System-Justification, Political Hope, Human Flourishing, & Racial Identity

Background: The PPAD survey centers on psychological questions of meaning, happiness, hopefulness about American democracy, and perceptions on the integrity of the US system. In addition to an age variable, the survey includes ordinal, categorical, and dichotomous variables within five categories: three more demographic variables, seven variables for human flourishing, a democratic hope variable, five political efficacy variables, and opinions on the US system.

Hypotheses: System justification theory suggests that individuals may extend favorable views not only to themselves or their group, but to the broader social system itself.[1] Cognitive dissonance, survivorship bias, and false consciousness each inform this theoretical framing. We also conduct additional racial identity hypotheses.

- H1a–H5a: Respondents who report higher flourishing within the American system will also report greater political hope.
- H6a–H7a: We examine differences in political hope by racial identity (African American and Latinx).
- H6b–H7c: We further hypothesize that African American and Latinx respondents will exhibit more cynical perceptions regarding power and government inefficiency, based on similar work on documented disparities in homeownership (K.-Y. Taylor), income (R. Chetty), wealth (W. Darity), and voter participation (C. Cohen).

Descriptive Statistics: The native sample size is 3,568; and attenuates to 3,126 given weighting. Observations for variables again attenuate - given missing or skipped values in the raw data.[2] Table A presents descriptive statistics.

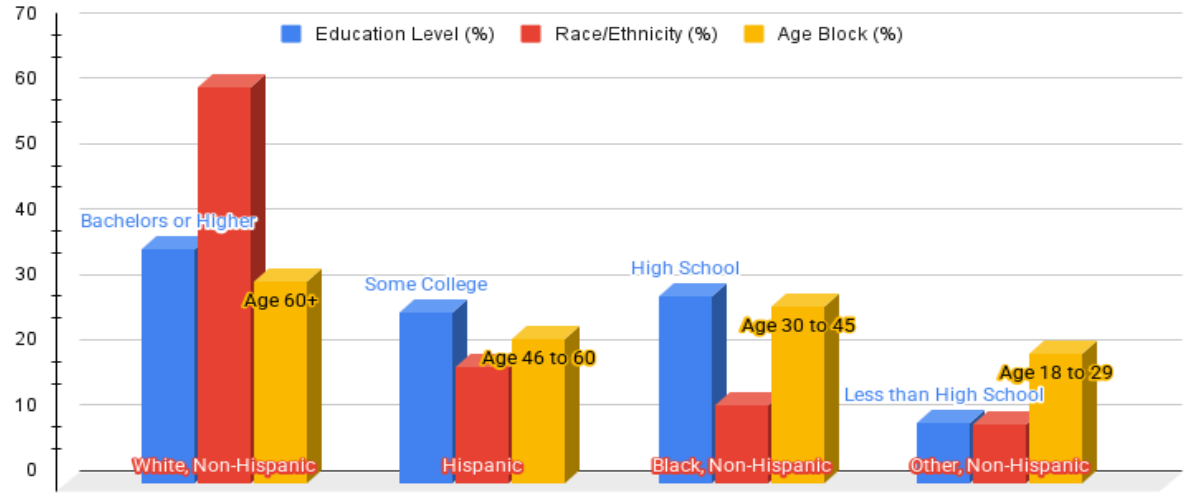
Table A: Descriptive Statistics (With Weighting and After Recoding and Shifts)

	Name	Obs	Missing	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Political Hope	Hope1nu	2,680	449	4.37	2.41	1	10
Happiness	HUMFL1nu	2,694	434	6.81	2.12	0	10
Worthwhileness	HUMFL2nu	2,694	435	7.65	2.07	0	10
Purposefulness	HUMFL3_1nu	2,676	458	7.14	2.43	0	10
Worries about Expenses	HUMFL6_1nu	2,684	446	7.06	2.83	0	10
Worries about Basics	HUMFL6_2nu	2,679	455	7.41	2.67	0	10
Perceptions on Power	COMP_ECONnu	2,655	486	0.30	0.46	0	1
Perceptions on Waste	COMP_GOVTnu	2,639	501	0.45	0.50	0	1

[1] Jost, J. T., & Banaji, M. R. (1994). The role of stereotyping in the system‐justification and the production of false consciousness. *British journal of social psychology*, *33*(1), 1-27.
[2] We re-coded variable values of -1 to "." and five variables downward by one given off-by-one problems.

Chart A visually presents groupings by percentage and after weighting for education, race, and age.[3] The weights shift the representativeness of the survey away from older, educated Whites. The scale of the ordinal values are progressive; for example, a higher value for the hope variable means more political hopefulness. Contrarily, the dichotomous variables for perceptions of power and inefficiency are regressive. For instance, the 0 for the perception of power values indicates a perception that the country unfairly favors powerful interests.

Chart A: Education, Race, & Age (as Percentages and After Weighting)



Methods: Below outline the methods,

- For hypotheses H1a–H5a, we use Pearson correlation (with weights) assuming normality and equidistant ordinal scaling.
- For H6a and H7a, we use point-biserial Pearson correlations for dichotomous racial indicators.
- For H6b–H7c, involving two dichotomous variables, we use Pearson's phi coefficient (φ) (equivalent to Pearson r for 2x2 tables).[4]

Interpretation: Tables B–E report correlation coefficients, significance, and sample sizes.

- We fail to reject the null hypotheses for H1a–H5a at the 99% confidence level, but we find consistent, if modest, positive correlations:
    - Example: H1a (Hope vs. Happiness): $r = 0.24$, $p < .001$, $N = 2{,}680$.
- Racial identity results are more ambiguous:
    - African American respondents show slightly more cynical views on power ($\varphi = -0.06$, $p < .001$).
    - Latinx respondents tend to report slightly more political hope (rpb = 0.06, $p < .001$) and greater belief that the US government is competent ($\varphi = 0.07$, $p < .001$).

[3] The raw age data is an integer; chart A uses an age group variable built in the analysis.
[4] The sensitivity analysis below reports the results of a Spearman correlation approach and also discusses (without reporting results) other rank-based methods.

Table B: Hope & Flourishing (Pearson)			
Hope1	obs	r	p
HUMFL1nu (H1a)	2,680	0.24	0.00
HUMFL2nu (H2a)	2,680	0.19	0.00
HUMFL3_1nu (H3a)	2,665	0.19	0.00
HUMFL6_1nu (H4a)	2,670	0.18	0.00
HUMFL6_2nu (H5a)	2,665	0.16	0.00

Table C: Hope & Race (Pearson Point-Biserial)			
Hope1	obs	rpb	p
AA (H6a)	2,680	0.05	0.01
LX (H7a)	2,680	0.06	0.00

Table D: Power & Race (Pearson-Phi)			
COMP_ECON	obs	φ	p
AA (H6b)	2,655	-0.06	0.00
LX (H7b)	2,655	0.04	0.03

Table E: Inefficiency & Race (Pearson Phi)			
COMP_GOVT	obs	φ	p
AA (H6c)	2,639	0.01	0.51
LX (H7c)	2,639	0.07	0.00

Sensitivity Analysis: Pairwise deletion under Pearson deletes more observations than listwise deletion under Spearman. Spearman correlations—which assume ordinal data without requiring equidistant spacing or normality—are more robust, especially when manually weighted.[5]

- For H1a–H5a, Spearman coefficients nearly double those of Pearson, with similar statistical significance.
- For racial identity hypotheses, Spearman generally leads to more null rejections, with the exception of H6a.

Table B: Hope & Flourishing (Spearman)			
Hope1	obs	rs	p
HUMFL1nu (H1a)	3,568	0.48	0.00
HUMFL2nu (H2a)	3,568	0.44	0.00
HUMFL3_1nu (H3a)	3,568	0.43	0.00
HUMFL6_1nu (H4a)	3,568	0.40	0.00
HUMFL6_2nu (H5a)	3,568	0.39	0.00

Table C: Hope & Race (Spearman)			
Hope1	obs	rs	p
AA (H6a)	3,568	0.08	0.00
LX (H7a)	3,568	0.04	0.01

Table D: Power & Race (Spearman)			
COMP_ECON	obs	rs	p
AA (H6b)	3,568	-0.04	0.03
LX (H7b)	3,568	-0.00	0.97

Table E: Inefficiency & Race (Spearman)			
COMP_GOVT	obs	rs	p
AA (H6c)	3,568	0.03	0.10
LX (H7c)	3,568	0.05	0.01

[5] Manually incorporating weights for Kendall correlation and Wilcoxon/Mann-Whitney measures are each different.

Future Study: The dataset invites further exploration of moral hazard and political psychology. Three later survey items—concerning jury duty, long-standing principles, and constraints on freedom—can provide insight into discipline, moral conservatism, and ideological commitment. Given that age is approximately normal and continuous, future models can more easily incorporate it. A regression framework will deepen analysis, especially for addressing endogeneity and potential reverse causality.